St 1818" P. 406–[89] I give you the title of the book because as you know ancient history it may amuse you: And I will tell you another tho' perhaps not such a good one as the book one. A little boy had gone into a Mosk, just after sunset when the people were there for evening prayers, and crouched in a corner he saw a man covered with rugs and filth, his hair matted and his whole body wasted to a skeleton. This man was continually calling out. "Is there no true believer here who will give a wretch who is near dying something to support his strength during the night" "Is there no one here who will give me a supper for the love of Allee." The boy went home and brought the man a basin of soup and two or three cakes of bread, the beggar said let the basin remain here and come and take it away tomorrow morning. He did so and in the morning found instead of his own basin, which was of copper tinned outside and consequently white, a basin of yellow metal roughly beaten together. The boy was at first disappointed, but when he showed it to others he found it was of pure gold.

You will probably see the translation of a letter which Bahman Meerza wrote to Dr Wolff published in a Constantinople paper. I made the translation for him and a pretty business it was. I understand there is to be a grand meeting at Exeter Hall when the doctor arrives in London: I hope they will give him something substantial for he is by no means rich.

The other day I had to write a letter in French and I can not tell you the time and trouble it gave me and after all it must have been a most clumsey performance. I believe I could have written the same thing in Persian in one quater the time. I have just recollected that I have never sent you a specimen of my Persian writing it is not so good as a schoolboys exercise but you may like it because it is mine. N°. 1 are four lines from Hafiz N°. 2 from the Gulistan of Sadi. I write Persian by no means well or correctly but with ease to myself. I read it with much more difficulty and I very often receive letters which I can not read.

Tabreez, May 7, 1845

Dr Wolff will I believe be in England before this reaches you. I trust they will give him something substantial as a reward for his dangers and hardships. He was always eccentric and since his return many people think him rather cracked. It may be so. Many doctors have a theory that every one is so, more or less. — My friend Dr Bell used to say that every Englishman who had been more than

[89] Kinneir, John Macdonald. *Journey through Asia Minor, Armenia, and Koordistan, in the years 1813 and 1814; with remarks on the marches of Alexander, and retreat of the Ten Thousand.* London: John Murray, Albemarle Street, 1818. p. 406–7 has a long footnote containing the story of an "Arabian philosopher" who transmuted four lead bullets to an equal weight of gold. It is interesting to note that stories of this character, like those pertaining to the Indian rope trick, are always related by someone who knows someone (who knows someone) . . .

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